



THE LAST HARVEST OF WILLOWBROOK

A SIMPLE ONE-SHOT ADVENTURE FOR D&D
5TH EDITION

For 3–5 Characters of Levels 1–3

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ADVENTURE SUMMARY

The small village of **Willowbrook** has two days before the brutal **Crimson Blades** bandit gang arrives to take their harvest and burn the village.

The player characters can help the villagers prepare. What they choose to do (or not do) during those two days will directly affect how difficult the final battle becomes.

This version focuses on **reactive choices** during preparation and builds to one big, memorable boss fight inside the village mill.

KEY NPCs

Elder Thorne – Practical leader who wants to avoid bloodshed.

Mira Stonehand – Runs the mill. Fierce and proud. The mill is everything to her.

Old Garrick – Retired fighter. Can train the villagers if convinced.

Sister Elara – Kind priest who keeps hope alive.

Tomas – Reckless teenage boy who wants to prove himself.

ACT 1: THE VILLAGE NEEDS HELP

The party arrives as the villagers argue in the square. They turn to the adventurers and ask what they should do.

Main Choice:

- Convince the village to stay and fight (most common path)
- Help them flee (shorter, easier adventure)
- Try to negotiate (fails, lowers morale)

Once the party agrees to defend the village, they have **two days** to prepare.

ACT 2: TWO DAYS TO PREPARE (CHOICES MATTER)

The party will have limited time. Their choices here will make the final fight inside the mill **easier or much harder**.

PREPARATION OPTIONS & CONSEQUENCES

1. Train the Militia (Old Garrick)

- If successful: The villagers fight with some skill and courage.
- **Effect on final fight:** 2–4 villagers can help hold the mill doors or provide minor support during the boss fight.

2. Fortify the Mill (Important!)

- The party can help barricade the doors, block windows, stack grain sacks for cover, or set simple traps.
- **Effect on final fight:**
 - Good fortifications = The party has cover and difficult terrain for enemies inside the mill.
 - Poor/no fortifications = Varga and his men can rush in easily. The fight is much more dangerous.

3. Scout the Bandits

- If the party sneaks out and spies on the Crimson Blades:
 - They learn the bandits are **terrified of fire** (they were burned badly once before).
- **Effect on final fight:** The party can use torches, oil, or grain dust explosions inside the mill as a powerful (but risky) weapon against Varga.

4. Help Specific Villagers

- **Help Mira:** She will stand and fight inside the mill with the party.
- **Help Old Garrick:** He fights alongside the party in the final battle.
- **Look after Tomas:** He survives and can do something small but brave (or tragic if ignored).
- **Support Sister Elara:** She keeps the other villagers calm and provides minor healing during the fight.

5. Boost Overall Morale

- Giving speeches, helping people, or showing they care.
- **Effect on final fight:** Villagers are less likely to break. High morale makes the whole defense feel more heroic.

Time Pressure: The party only has two days. They must choose what matters most.

ACT 3: THE ATTACK & THE FINAL STAND IN THE MILL

THE BATTLE REACHES THE VILLAGE

Describe the Crimson Blades attacking at dawn. Use the party's preparation to narrate how the initial fighting goes:

- Good fortifications elsewhere → Bandits are slowed down.
- Trained militia + high morale → Villagers put up a real fight.
- Fire weakness discovered → The party can use it to create chaos early.

Eventually, the bandits break through and push toward the **mill** — the heart of the village.

Captain Varga decides to personally lead the assault on the mill. He wants to crush the last resistance in the most symbolic place.

THE CLIMACTIC FIGHT: INSIDE THE MILL

This is the big, memorable finale.

Set the Scene The mill is a large wooden building with heavy grinding stones, thick wooden support beams, grain sacks, a loft area, and big doors that open toward the river. It smells of grain and dust. Windows are high and small. It can feel like a fortress... or a deathtrap.

The Fight

Captain Varga enters with a small group of his best men. The exact difficulty depends on how well the party prepared.

How Preparation Affects This Fight:

Preparation Done	Effect on the Final Fight	Difficulty
Fortified the mill well	Cover from grain sacks, barricaded doors, difficult terrain for enemies	Much Easier
Trained militia + high morale	2–4 villagers help hold the entrance or assist in the fight	Easier
Learned the fire weakness	Party can create fire hazards or explosions (risky but strong)	Easier
Helped Mira	Mira fights alongside the party	Easier
Helped Old Garrick	Garrick fights with the party	Easier
Did very little preparation	Varga has extra bodyguards. No cover. Villagers panic	Much Harder

Running the Fight (Simple & Dramatic)

- Start with Varga and 1–2 bodyguards entering.
- If the party prepared poorly, add 1–2 more bandits.
- If the party prepared well, the fight stays focused on Varga + 1 bodyguard.
- Use the environment: grain sacks for cover, beams to climb, grain dust that can explode if fire is used.
- Varga is arrogant. He taunts the party and focuses on the strongest-looking character.
- If the party uses fire creatively (especially if they scouted), it can turn the tide dramatically.

Goal of the Fight Defeat Varga. When he falls, the remaining bandits lose heart and flee (especially if the party used fire or the villagers are still holding strong).

You don't need a long, complicated battle. One solid, tense fight inside the mill is enough.

Possible Dramatic Moments

- A barricade breaks and more bandits try to rush in.
- Tomas does something brave (or reckless).
- Mira or Garrick takes a wound protecting someone.
- The party uses the mill's environment in a clever way.

AFTERMATH

If the party wins the fight inside the mill (especially with good preparation):

- The village is saved.
- Most named NPCs survive.
- The party is celebrated as heroes.
- They receive thanks, and a modest reward.

If the fight was very hard or they barely won:

- The village survives but is damaged.
- One or two named NPCs may die.
- The overall tone is bittersweet.

If they lose the fight in the mill:

- The mill burns. Many villagers die or are captured.
- The party can still escape with some survivors.
- Possibly opens the door to a future story.

VARIOUS POINTERS

- Make the players feel the pressure during the two days of preparation.
- Describe small moments with the villagers so the players care about them.
- The final fight inside the mill should climatic and important.
- The preparation choices not only adjusts difficulty, but also tone.
- The mill battle doesn't have to be long, but it does need to be dramatic and memorable.

STAT BLOCK

CAPTAIN VARGA IRONHAND

Medium humanoid, chaotic evil

Armor Class 15 (studded leather)

Hit Points 65 (10d8 + 20)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws Str +5, Dex +4, Wis +2

Skills Athletics +5, Deception +4, Intimidation +4

Senses passive Perception 10

Languages Common

Challenge 2 (450 XP)

Leadership: Varga can shout commands to his allies. Until the start of his next turn, each ally within 30 feet of him that can hear him has advantage on attack rolls.

ACTIONS

Multiattack: Varga makes three attacks: two with his scimitar and one with his dagger.

Scimitar: Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d6 + 3) slashing damage.

Dagger: Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage.

REACTION

Parry: Varga adds 2 to his AC against one melee attack that would hit him. He must be wielding a melee weapon and see the attacker.